

Viva la Revolución

After World War I, Latin America entered a period of social unrest and political change that was created in part by the impact of economic crisis. Populist movements, some authoritarian, others revolutionary, swept new regimes to power. In some countries, governments were imposed on the population by the military.



The Peróns

Juan Perón and his wife Eva address an economic planning meeting in Buenos Aires. Although Eva Perón was not elected, she was influential in her husband's government. They enjoyed cult status in Argentina, and Eva's death in 1952 resulted in scenes of mass mourning.

BEFORE

300 years of colonial rule by the Spanish and Portuguese came to an end in Latin America at the beginning of the 19th century.

INDEPENDENCE FROM COLONIAL RULE

The transition from colonial rule to self-government in Latin America <<318–19 was generally smooth in terms of economic stability. In the early years of the 20th century, many Latin American countries had **flourishing economies**, based on the **export of crops and minerals** to North America and Europe.

85 PERCENT of land in Brazil was owned by one percent of the population in 1910.

THE MEXICAN REVOLUTION

Mexico's popular uprising of 1910 preceded and influenced the revolutions in Russia <<376–77 and Eastern Europe. **Porfirio Díaz's** military regime was overthrown in 1911, but widespread conflict continued as Mexican soldiers, workers, and peasants joined in a **struggle for civil rights and agricultural reform**. Although briefly calmed by the Constitutional Congress of Mexico in 1917, violence flared again in the 1920s.

DEPRESSION AND INDUSTRIALIZATION

The **world economic crisis** triggered by the market crash of 1929, and the ensuing Great Depression <<384–85, devastated Latin America's export market and **created shortages** in imported manufactured goods. The political response was to create economies that could provide for their own populations without reliance on foreign markets. The 1930s saw **rapid industrialization** and urban growth.

SOCIAL UNREST

In trends similar to those of 19th-century Europe <<336–37, the growth in Latin America's **urban workforce** led to a rise in **political activism** and **calls for social and political change**.

"The Arsenal"

This 1928 mural by Mexican artist Diego Rivera shows his wife, the painter Frida Kahlo, handing arms to workers. Rivera and Kahlo belonged to the Mexican communist party. The fall of Díaz's regime (see above) in Mexico set a precedent that popular uprising could succeed.

In 1930, economic problems led the Brazilian military to install Getulio Vargas as provisional president. Although it operated as a dictatorship—a government ruled by one person with absolute power and no recognized opposition, or restriction from the country's law—his government permitted liberal measures such as social and welfare reforms. For several years, Vargas followed a modernization program, but, alarmed at the growth of communist support in the 1930s, he began to model the state along fascist lines (see pp.386–87), proclaiming an *Estado Novo* ("New Order"). Hitler's Germany became a major customer for Brazilian goods, and Vargas supported the Axis powers (Germany, Italy, and Japan) at the start of World War II.

In 1941, Vargas changed his allegiance to the Allies (Britain, the US, the USSR, and France). This caused the military to force Vargas from office in 1945. He was democratically reelected in 1951, but committed suicide in 1954, after the army demanded his resignation.

Perón's "Third Way"

In Argentina, a populist government came to power in 1946 led by Juan Perón. "Peronism" was a contradictory mixture of progressive social values and authoritarian rule that Perón called the "Third Way." He transformed manufacturing in Argentina, launching an iron and steel industry, and ship and car production. Radical change came as women were given the vote, and corporations were nationalized. At the height of his popularity, Perón and his second wife Eva, known as "Evita,"

commanded huge mass support. Comparisons have been made with fascist regimes, and although he never pursued mass violence, he did crush any opposition to his rule. Argentina also provided a safe haven for Nazi war criminals after World War II.

Cuba breaks with the US

In Cuba, the military regime of Fulgencio Batista was overthrown after a long struggle with revolutionaries. Having trained in Mexico, Fidel Castro landed in Cuba in 1956 with an army of political exiles, including Che Guevara (see RIGHT). A guerrilla war ensued, in which small groups of armed rebels carried out repeated attacks to wear down the enemy, before the rebels seized power in 1959. Castro swiftly ended US dominance of Cuba's economy. Taking aid from the USSR, he implemented radical reforms including a Soviet-style agricultural policy (see pp.380–81). The 1962 Cuban Missile Crisis (see pp.406–07) further damaged US–Cuban relations. The US continues to impose an economic embargo on Cuba, but Fidel Castro's regime still survives.

Chile's brief democracy

In 1970 an increased desire for extreme political change, or radicalism, brought socialist Salvador Allende to the Chilean presidency. Concerns were raised in the US when Allende established diplomatic relations with communist regimes in Cuba, China, North Korea, and North Vietnam. He attempted to restructure Chile's unstable economy, but was soon threatened by a variety

of political opponents. Eager to influence the next regime, the US backed General Augusto Pinochet's military coup against Allende in 1973. When attackers entered the presidential palace, Allende was found dead from a gunshot wound.

Castro's camp

This photograph, taken around 1957, shows the bearded revolutionary leader Fidel Castro with commanders of his rebel army at a secret camp in Cuba. The rebels were poorly armed, but Castro's guerrilla tactics won the conflict.



REVOLUTIONARY (1928–1967)

ERNESTO "CHE" GUEVARA

Che Guevara was born in Argentina in 1928. As a young man, he traveled extensively in Latin America, and became convinced that only revolution would solve the problems of poverty and social inequality that marked the continent. A visit to President Guzmán's populist regime in Guatemala in 1953 confirmed Che's enthusiasm for radical political solutions and, in 1956, he joined Fidel Castro's rebel army. In 1965, Che left Cuba with the intention of sparking revolutions in other countries. He was captured by the CIA—the US secret service—in Bolivia in 1967, and executed by the Bolivian army.



AFTER

After authoritarian, often military-backed regimes in the 1960s and 1970s, many Latin American nations became more democratic.

COUNTERREVOLUTION

In the 1970s, the revolutionary and socialist ideals of previous decades were swept aside. **Military regimes 438–39 >>** were established in many countries, including Uruguay and Argentina.

ANTI-AMERICANISM

Left-wing presidents such as Venezuela's **Hugo Chávez** (from 1999) **438 >>** and Bolivia's **Evo Morales** (from 2006) have increasingly spoken out against US policy in Latin America.